Wallen siblings in conversation

Helen: I have a business called […]. Between that and the kids, that's all my time. Two kids, I have a 2 and 4 year old. And the daily grind everyone else seems to be going through. Through Corona, during state 4 I stayed home with the kids but because we are in the food business we're deemed "essential" so we were allowed to be open. But it felt wrong when the rest of the state was locked down, so I stayed home with the kids and we had only 2 still here working for the 6 weeks.

Interviewer: Gee, that must have been hard with kids so little. Tell me about the business.

Helen: We're in Australian natives. We work with Indigenous communities and local growers to source native produce. We are predominantly an ingredients supplies – we have some of our own products – but we supply ingredients to beverage and food suppliers and the food service. I don't know if you watch MasterChef, but we supply the native ingredients to MasterChef. So, when they use those ingredients, they're ours.

Interviewer: Wow.

Helen: So, it's been a great journey. It's been five years now and it's been - it's really rewarding. You get to see the change in the industry. You work in an industry that's growing from virtually nothing and kind of talking to people and talking about the story of these native ingredients and the health benefits, the flavour profiles, and just seeing people kind of have this moment of, "Oh, my god, how am I Australian and I don't know about these ingredients? How do I not know about this produce that has the highest vitamin C content, yet we're importing superfoods from overseas?" Like, it's a real - it's an 'a hah moment', and it kind of clicks and it makes sense for people.

Interviewer: Yes There's that patriotic idea and then there's the economics of food miles and why do I need to buy things that have travelled thousands of kilometres to get here? And then there's also the -

Helen: Exactly.

Interviewer: - how could I have lived here my whole life and there are things that we should be proud of.

Helen: Exactly.

Interviewer: Not just because they're healthy, but because they're ours and we've never - all excited about goji berries, but we have our own produce. Helen, tell me. How old are you?.

Helen: I'm 34.

Interviewer: And you, Adrian?

Adrian: I'm going well. I just got back from Perth two days ago. So, yeah, we've been in Perth for probably just shy of six weeks. Yeah, we were able to get over there just because our daughter has got a respiratory issue. She had a double

aortic arch. I don't know if that means anything. So, two aortas off the heart. It constricted her trachea during pregnancy, so she essentially has what's called the tracheomalacia, which is a floppy trachea. She'll be fine in the long run, it's just that when COVID was kind of taking off, her doctors were a little bit concerned. They'd said, "if she gets it, it will not be great for her". So, they said, "if you can get over to Perth, get over to Perth". So, we did that. So, we came back a couple of days ago just with numbers being so low and my wife, [Adrian's wife], the business she works for requiring her to be in Melbourne pre-Christmas. So, yeah, that was nice to be over there and that's what we've been doing. And do you want to know from my work perspective?

Interviewer: So your daughter went for some kind of procedure in Western Australia? Was that -

Adrian: No, no. She had her procedure within two weeks of being born. This was really to kind of escape COVID.

Helen: No, like if she gets - like, when she gets a cold, she often - in the past, she's ended up in ICU. So, it was prevent - because if she was to get COVID, it would be really dire.

Interviewer: Right, I understand. Okay.

Adrian: Yeah, yeah. So, yeah, we went over there for six weeks, which was really nice and warm.

Helen: And come back to five days of zeroes.

Interviewer: Fair enough. Yes. Adrian, what line of work are you in?

Adrian: So, Helen's husband and I, [Helen's husband], have a business that - we've got a few businesses now. Our first business, we do architectural and engineering, drafting, 3D modelling. It's an offshore play, so we've also got an office in [Asian country] and service architects, engineers, home builders, the home builders. And, so, that's one business called […]. The second is […]. So, we're basically taking those 3D models and pushing them into gaming engine technology and essentially enabling people to experience their home before it's built. Photo-realism, interactivity, data connected - you can essentially walk through any space, change product, material, family floorplan options -

Interviewer: Wow.

Adrian: Yeah, that's really cutting-edge stuff. That's really exciting. It also happens to be the one I'm taking care of at the moment. I'm most excited about that. But the business that [Helen's husband] looks after, […], pays all the bills at the moment, so that's nice. And the third business is called […], and it's basically leveraging our [Asian country] office to - if you're a business, come to us, tell us what your needs are and we will undertake that whole employment process for you. So, go and find good candidates, bring them to you - it's all a very transparent process. We bring you the final three to you as the prospective customer: are these the guys that you want? These are the guys that we've found, rather, and tell us if they're suitable or not, and then they work from our office in [Asian country] and, yeah, [Asian country] has certain industries where they are better known: technology, finance, architecture and engineering being

Commented [User1]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme captures "interactional action units" where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to corroborate or challenge shared history, preventing the distortion of personal or family narratives.

Family Health Narrative : Adrian initially frames their move to Perth as a way to "escape COVID." Helen immediately provides **narrative repair** to clarify the stakes: "No, like if she gets - like, when she gets a cold, she often... ended up in ICU. So, it was prevent - because if she was to get COVID, it would be really dire."

a few of them. So, that's basically the third business, and that's quite new. We only started that kind of mid this year.

Interviewer: Wow.

Adrian: Yeah. It's cutting-edge technology. We're trying to make it so - leverage technology to enable your average mum and dad to have the eye of an architect.

Helen: It would have let you put the tiles on the wall, you'd see them and then you could press a button and it would change, and those tiles would change and you'd be able to see it in that room.

Interviewer: Nice.

Helen: And see the price as well, as you change it. Okay, that's going to cost me an extra couple of hundred dollars or whatever.

—

Interviewer: Thank you for coming. The purpose of the focus group that I'm running at the moment, and I'm doing this across sort of different Australian Jewish families looking at where - rather than having parents talk about their kids or have individual speak about themselves, I wanted to hear about people who had all been raised under the same roof. So, they could sort of say, well, here's where I am now professionally, family-wise, life-stage-wise, and also Jewishly, and these are the experiences in my upbringing that I attribute to how I see myself Jewishly now. And I don't want to put any words in your mouths. I prefer to hear it from you. A snapshot where you are Jewishly now. Now, the words people use to describe themselves, I'll leave those words to you, and I'm just interested Jewishly where you see yourself now and then maybe after we do that round, go to upbringing and take that from there. Helen, do you want to start?

Helen: Yep. So, Jewishly, day to day, [oldest child] is at [Traditional Jewish school] and [second child] is at [Jewish childcare centre]. We recognise that we're - so, we're going to talk about what we came from later, but we celebrate Shabbat every week. For the chagim we go to shul for ten minutes for the High Holidays. Or, for half an hour. It's kind of **whatever we can do with the kids** and it's never a really spiritual moment for us, but I think that **it's just being there and having the kids hear the shofar and seeing - well, not this year, but seeing the Sukkot up in shul**.

We do things at home. More from the traditional sense and more to give the kids the experience than from a religious sense. So, for Sukkot this year we have a covered area outside. We put up a Sukkah that you could see through it and see the stars, it had schach. But when we drove to the beach yesterday, [oldest child] pointed at the palm trees and said "that's schach ". So, that was - yay, [Traditional Jewish school]. We have Shabbat every week and we do the prayers and probably for each chag I'm definitely doing more than I was doing pre-kids because I try and make it really special, because I want Judaism**, I want the chagim to be a big memory for the kids** when they grow up about how special the chagim were. And, so, we put a lot of emphasis on that. So,

like, for Purim - we live in East Malvern, so there's not a really high Jewish population around where we are, but we went and we handed out mishloah manot to all our neighbours and those sorts of things. We do day-to-day chag-to-chag.

How I feel spiritually about Judaism? I don't think I ever really - I don't think I'm a highly religious person. I don't really believe in God, but I love Judaism and I love how it makes me feel as part of a community and how it brings the community together. I love those elements.

Interviewer: Right, cool. Adrian?

Adrian: From a family perspective, similarly to Helen, we do - well, we used to do Shabbat together. Now we do Shabbat on Zoom or at least the beginnings of it. With all the kids at different ages, we typically are getting the Zoom done for the Kiddush and the prayers, as quickly as we can so that we can go back quickly to the routine of bathing and getting kids to bed and what not. So, it's a little bit rushed these days, but we're already talking - Helen and I spoke last night. We're already talking about our - the upcoming weeks in terms of Shabbat and whose houses and what not. So, we'll get back into that routine pretty quickly.

From a – [oldest child] is not in school yet. What school she'll go to is an ongoing discussion. We like the idea of a Jewish day school, but it might not be [Traditional Jewish school], and that's not because of me. There are certain things I like about [Traditional Jewish school] from a kid's - from my own experiences. I think that [Adrian's wife] came from Perth, came from [Modern Orthodox school], a much smaller school. She really enjoyed parts and that. So, **we're just kind of balancing what that all looks like at the moment**, whether it's [Progressive Jewish school], whether it's [Traditional Jewish school], whether it's [Bundist Jewish school], but it looks like to be one of those. We're also open - part of our discussion is not going to a Jewish day school as well, but the thing that pulls us back to the Jewish day school is all the things that Helen talked about and fortunately or unfortunately neither of us really have the time to take on the whole informal Jewish day - curriculum if she doesn't. So, I think that that is probably - she'll be in one of the Jewish day schools mostly likely.

Then from my personal kind of standpoint, I kind of - depending on the life - sometimes with the life experiences and before [oldest child] was born I would say similar to Helen, like I'm not a big believer in God as such, but I do love the sense of community and my kind of many of - who I call my group of best mates are my group of best mates since kindergarten. The likes of [lists six friends].

Interviewer: That's lovely. Adrian, how old are you now?

Adrian: Me, I'm 35. Is that right, Helen?

Helen: 35 -

Adrian: [Helen's husband] just turned 36. I'm 35. Yeah, basically for anything in my life I don't have an answer to is I ask [Helen's husband].

Interviewer: Good to have that clarification. Ethan?

Commented [User2]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme distinguishes between **identity optimization** (refining stable commitments) and fundamental crises, mapping the move from **conferred** (parental) to **agentic** (chosen) identity.

Parental Identity Optimization: Helen describes doing "more than I was doing pre-kids" regarding rituals (Sukkot, Shabbat). This is a clear example of **identity optimization**—she increases practice not out of a theological crisis, but as a "pragmatic" way to ensure the *chagim* (festivals) are a "big memory for the kids."

Commented [User3]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (systemic), Relational (family), and Individual levels.

Mesosystemic Filtering: The siblings negotiate the "balancing" of where to send their children to school—weighing [Traditional Jewish school] vs. [Progressive school] vs. [Bundist school] against logistics and the "informal Jewish curriculum"

Cross-reference: Point continued below (&&)

Commented [User4]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme captures "interactional action units" where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to corroborate or challenge shared history, preventing the distortion of personal or family narratives.

Verification of Age: Adrian turns to Helen to verify his own age ("Is that right, Helen?"). Helen provides the **intersubjective grounding**: "35 - [Helen's husband] just turned 36. I'm 35."

Ethan: Until recently we were in San Francisco and then we came here to have a baby and we're still here now, but I still am actually employed by - I haven't quit or anything, so I haven't changed certain things.

Helen: But he's working here as well.

Interviewer: Right. And you're in anaesthesiology?

Ethan: Yeah.

Interviewer: And where are you sitting now Jewishly?

Ethan: Where am I sitting Jewishly? I've always felt pretty - a strong connection to Judaism. That would sort of manifest itself through the stuff I've especially. Like, I've studied antisemitism and Holocaust studies and that type of thing at uni and certainly connection to the Holocaust, person/family connection, and things like that, and then connection to Israel was very very strong and has sharply declined in the last ten years, I would say. Sharply. Sadly. But I can't deny that.

Helen: Yep.

Adrian: Yeah.

Ethan: Okay, good. I just don't want to talk for half an hour and then realise no-one is there. So, yeah, that's sort of my personal thing.

I do value the traditions and things like that, but I think from what I've heard our community say - people in my cohort and the like people - while I do think that the rituals and things are important, I think that Judaism wasn't taught that well to us and I think that our relationship with Judaism suffered and I think that people's relationship with Judaism - when I say 'people', I say the Jewish community in Melbourne especially, not everyone's but a lot of people's, it was sort of - when you were at school it was a punitive thing which you had to do which detracted from the sort of meaning of it and enjoyment. But definitely from the meaning and people I think - and I speak partly from experience - if you ask me about festivals and halacha and that kind of thing, I actually wouldn't be able to tell you that much, to be honest. It would be like, "what is Sukkot?" And I'd be able to give you some lines on it, but it wouldn't be a deep deep understanding of the various aspects to it. I think that - and I wouldn't be alone in that regard - and I think that certainly the more Jewish themes would be more important to me and would be more important to convey to my kids, then. You put this matzah on that matzah and that kind of thing.

So, yeah, I think we were sort of - our Jewish education was sub-optimal and I think that also ties into our shul experiences too. I think they were really - they were demonstrably sub-optimal and laid the groundwork for people not to go to shul, at least by choice. It was always out of obligation and those reasons for going - especially our Holocaust-surviving grandparents and parents and they're all going to be gone soon, and people will go for their kids, but **there's never a time when they went for themselves**. They're always going for someone else. And I've had shul experiences since then in San Francisco, a couple in Israel and even some in Melbourne that are really different and far

more sort of I think progressed in my opinion. So, that's sort of where I am personally.

And then with regard to my kids, very much in that area now of **weighing up whether Jewish education is for our kids**. So, literally [they're] on the cusp - front of mind right now for several reasons, but some of them logistics, some of them sort of related to the context that you bring your kids up in and the community and that type of thing. So, I think our decision won't be just based whether we want - in and of itself I would love my kids to have a Jewish education, but it depends at what cost and what things they're sort of forgoing, and I think that **you have to balance those** and make a call.

Interviewer: It sounds like you weren't particularly happy with your Jewish education.

Ethan: No, no, I don't mean to disparage. I think it was - I think I always had **the inner voice of my mum**. Like, I would feel more compelled to be more committed to that stuff than most of my classmates and my friends, and I chose Jewish subjects. I did Jewish Civilisation [Tertiary course offered in Secondary school]. I went on - when I went on Ulpan in 1999 I was ready to join the army and move to Israel and that kind of thing, and it didn't feel like brainwashing at the time, although that played a role. It was a very different Israel to the one that exists today, at least politically and culturally, and yeah, that - my relationship with Israel and by extension Israelis to an extent is very compromised at the moment.

Interviewer: Is that political in terms of your -

Ethan: Yes. Yes. Well, not just political. The sort of – leaving media manipulation blah blah blah aside – if the majority of Israelis are prepared to keep voting in someone like Netanyahu, I think my values have diverged from the majority of Israelis fundamentally. And when my values are with Breaking The Silence kind of people and they're marginalised soldiers and they're sort of pilloried in society, yeah. I've diverted. I've diverted from them and I've diverted from a lot of the, let's say, the Melbourne Jewish community too, to be brutally honest. And that will partly inform the community our kid grows up in.

Interviewer: I understand. Your family? Kids?

Ethan: Yeah, we have two kids. So, we had the second kid a few months ago.

Interviewer: That's awesome. Lovely.

Ethan: Thank you.

Interviewer: And, so, do you – Adrian, Helen, Ethan, do you see yourself Jewishly sitting in similar spaces or – from what Adrian and Helen were saying it seemed to be similar in sort of cultural and ritual experiences. Ethan, would you see that as different? I'm just trying to tease that out.

Ethan: No. They're not exclusive to each other. Because that's a very common thing in our community: very much ritualistic and even - which is a good thing and I think I keep the most kosher than anyone in our family for that reason, that's ritualistic. I don't think that makes me a better person or takes me closer to God or anything like that. It's purely a sort of repetitive sort of physical act that

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Mesosystemic Filtering: The siblings negotiate the "balancing" of where to send their children to school—weighing [Traditional Jewish school] vs. [Progressive school] vs. [Bundist school] against logistics and the "informal Jewish curriculum"

Cross-reference: Point continued (&&)

Commented [User6]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity rather than researcher-dictated scales.

"Inner Voice of My Mum": Ethan's term for the internalised moral and religious pressure that makes him feel "compelled" toward commitment despite his resentments.

Commented [User7]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme distinguishes between **identity optimization** (refining stable commitments) and fundamental crises, mapping the move from **conferred** (parental) to **agentic** (chosen) identity.

Political Reconsideration of Commitment: Ethan describes how his values have "diverged from the majority of Israelis" and the "Melbourne Jewish community." His "sharp decline" in connection to Israel over ten years represents a **reconsideration of commitment** based on individual political ethics.

reminds you of your Jewishness in a way. But I think that – [pauses] yeah, yeah. I don't think that's - for me, if it was the rituals or the meaning - not that they're necessarily different but they can be - I would go with the meaning, and I can think of friends and people I know who have a deeper understanding of the meaning but don't really hang on to the rituals as much and I don't mind that actually. Yeah. I don't know if I'm conveying what I'm thinking as well I think I am, but - I think that makes sense.

Adrian: I think that makes sense. I think I probably fall into that kind of, do the simple rituals you don't really follow; you don't really have the depth of understanding around a lot of it. I think that probably throughout my schooling life it wasn't - I always identified strongly with Israel but I never really listened or took the respective subjects seriously. Post-school for a number of years, I didn't really re-engage. I went to Israel. Did Maccabiah. I did all the things that kind of - that were - I did volunteer in Israel. I did all the things that connected me to Israel and Jewishly, but it was one of the actions rather than the depth. I worked for MDA and did those things, but it was because those things were interesting to me, and that's how I felt that I could connect Jewishly or to Israel. But, yeah, I never kind of - I think unlike Ethan, he wanted the meaning, whereas I was less inclined to do the extra hours to find out -

Ethan: Just on the thing Adrian said. I totally agree. To do the meaning side versus the ritual side I think takes much more knowledge and I can't pretend that I have enough of it to - like, I think if the people that have that knowledge that are sort of able to impart that depth to kids or students, and I don't think I have that. I think I have it on certain things, but not as much as I would want to do it well. But, yeah, I can't help but think the rituals are sort of there just - it's sort of more pragmatic, it's more practical. In a way, it's easier to convey those things. And I've watched in amazement actually - so, my kids, had really not had exposure to a Jewish school at all and within weeks of being at [Traditional Jewish school] she was sort of - basically like reciting songs and getting into it, which was great and lovely to see but the speed of it was almost like alarming in a way. Like, it was amazing. Yeah. I can see how that's important, especially in the early days, but it feels like sometimes we might not progress much beyond that as many years into schooling.

Helen: A lot has changed at [Traditional Jewish school] - well, in Jewish education in its entirety. Education has changed and the way that we were taught Judaism at school has changed a lot from how it's taught now. I remember even last year I had a meeting with […] and […] at [Traditional Jewish school] and we were talking about how we could connect wattle seed, which they're going to start growing in the kindergarten with Lag Ba'Omer and damper. So, like, bringing the cultures together. And I think that's something that we - we kind of had Jewish studies, we had English, Maths, and I think for a lot of students, Jewish studies was just that subject that they didn't care about.

Interviewer: From what I hear – and perhaps personal experience, there's a lot of optional things that you can choose to get involved in and I think that there's some kind of reverse psychology that the less you obligate high school students to do things, the more they sign up, which is kind of weird, but very salient.

Adrian: That sounds like me.

Interviewer: Yeah, it makes sense. You're respecting a young person enough to say that if this is important to you, then you'll come. It probably comes down to respect for people and giving them that opportunity to opt-in, but at the same time there's a catch-22 because they might opt-out and they might miss out on something. In parenthood it is similar. If a child has wandered into the middle of the road and a Range Rover is bearing straight at them, most would not offer that child the option of choosing whether to remain there or get out of the way. Most would not want to risk giving them that choice. Most would yank them off the road and save their lives. And then there's others -

Ethan: If there's a way to go, the Range Rover is the one. [Laughs] Sorry, that was kind of dark. Sorry. [i.e. letting the child choose, even if it kills them]

Interviewer: There's that dance with being a parent with kids and raising them in a community where Judaism is a choice, but that would probably translate to a high school level as well.

Any reflection on upbringings? There was a bit of a mention, particularly from Ethan, about school. For each of you, can you maybe think about something about the way you were raised, maybe home, an educational experience, a person - something about your upbringing that you feel best really explains why Jewishly you are the way you are now?

Ethan: Should we go by age? Inverse age.

Aidan: Yeah, got for it, Ethan.

Ethan: Okay. [Long pause] So, yeah, I mean some of it actually - everyone's experience is really personal and a lot of mine actually goes back to what you just said in the previous point, which is I sort of resented being forced to do stuff. It made me want to do it less even if I could see the value in it. And that principle went through to non-Jewish things, when I had my master's in my mid-30s when they made us sign into lectures and I just resented that and almost didn't want to go because of that. So, it didn't just relate to Judaism and that's a personality thing. And I can't help - we're a post-Holocaust generation that has sort of - is in every single part of the Judaism we practise, I think, and I think understandably our parents are obsessed with the Holocaust and that has its detrimental effects and its positives. I think it shapes a lot of their worldviews in ways that is distantly related at best and then we take in that and some of us keep that and some of us maybe don't. But certainly like - yeah, I found that was the dominating thing, was the Holocaust, and sort of the fear, and all the things associated with that. So, it was the fear of persecution, the fear of otherness, the very fact that you would hold onto your Judaism because we're victims. It's not everything, but I felt that came out a lot and understandably so sometimes. And I think it shapes our identity to a reasonable extent in conjunction with Israel.

So, yeah, certainly seen the importance of it to my **Mum** in particular, it was a **double-edged sword**. It's sort of like - I think it increased my - in one way I internalised some of that and in another way, it **drove me away** from certain things too, if that makes sense. So, she was definitely - she's a very passionate - I would say most passionate than a lot of parents in terms of her Judaism, and I think that sort of had a **bi-directional effect on me**.

Commented [User8]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (systemic), Relational (family), and Individual levels.

Individual-Level (The Self-Concept): Helen articulates a "shame/pride" dichotomy, while Ethan connects his **individual-level** "personality thing" (resenting being forced) to his **macro-level** separation from the Orthodox community.

Cross-reference: Point continue from above (==)

Commented [User9]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity rather than researcher-dictated scales.

"Double-Edged Sword" and "Driving Force": Participant-generated metaphors used by Ethan and Adrian to describe their mother's intense influence on their upbringing.

One thing I will reflect on is when we went to [city in USA] it was the first time in my life that it was our total decision, it was up to us what Judaism we were involved with essentially, and in particular, what synagogue we went to, and I just had such - I actually enjoyed going to synagogue. I tuned into their services from here during Yom Kippur and stuff, and it was an experience that was different to any synagogue I'd been to. And it has a value system, I think, that was very different to what I had experienced here and it was great and I think that kind of thing would appeal to lots of young people. There were times that it was really inspirational and moving and spiritual, and it was the farthest thing that I could think of from most of my shul experiences in Melbourne, for what that's worth.

Interviewer: What sort of shul did you go to in Melbourne and what sort of shul was it in San Francisco?

Ethan: So, we went to [small synagogue outside of the Jewish area] as little kids and then we moved onto [small Orthodox synagogue in Jewish area], which from - I feel like in the 90s that was actually regarded as semi-progressive. I might be totally misunderstanding that. We were pretty young. But I do remember there being much more song involved at the time. This is sort of maybe early to mid-90s and then we sort of moved across to [egalitarian synagogue in Jewish area] over time, which is obviously more - relatively more progressive. And this one I'm telling you about, The Kitchen - my wife converted Conservative and I think that whole thing, that whole experience was a positive one in terms of the conversion and simply [Conservative synagogue] is a great shul. I really thought it had lots of great people and they did it well, and we converted there because I didn't like the way the Orthodox community runs it here, the punitive nature, and the actually the fact that they don't recognise Conservative or Reform Jews as Jews. Now that that's my family, that's sort of intertwined in my separation from, my total separation from pretty much the entire Orthodox community, but also Israel as well because they're so powerful there now, and we had an experience like trying to sign our kid up for Chabad day-care or whatever, even though we probably weren't going to go there. They said, "have you converted?" "Yes". "Are you thinking of converting Orthodox?" "No". "Then, you can't come". I was like that's disappointing. That's disappointing for Judaism generally. I think that's like, given everything that is faced by Jews and blah, blah, blah, the fact that we've got exclusion within our religion and it just - yeah, I don't think that bodes well for our religion and I don't think it reflects of the community that I thought - well, that I was a part of. I'm sort of happy to sort of break away from it to an extent.

Interviewer: Gee. I'm sorry to hear that. The community in San Francisco, what kind of community was that?

Ethan: Sorry, that's where I was going. So, they're called The Kitchen. I found out about them through my uncle's connection to the leader of NIF in America. He goes there, so we just went there and the service was amazing. I would say they're between Reform and Conservative. They do the whole thing in Hebrew essentially but with some explanations. They chop little bits out to make things a little bit shorter but allow for a lot more singing and songs. They have instruments and electricity on Shabbes. It was - men and women sit together. So, all those things are not confronting to me. I know they are to some people.

Commented [User10]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme distinguishes between **identity optimization** (refining stable commitments) and fundamental crises, mapping the move from **conferred** (parental) to **agentic** (chosen) identity.

The Transition to Agentic Identity: Ethan notes that moving to a city in the USA was the first time in his life that his Judaism was a "total decision" and "up to us," moving away from the **conferred identity** of being "forced to do stuff" in Melbourne.

Cross-reference: Continued below (^^)

Commented [User11]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (systemic), Relational (family), and Individual levels.

Relational-Level (Family Dynamics): The transcript is dominated by the influence of a "very strong" and "passionate" mother. Adrian notes the **relational filtering** of this influence: it was a source of "good things" but also created memories he does not "look back fondly upon".

Cross-reference: Point continued below (++)

Yeah, so just a beautiful service and then sort of really inspirational drashot from the female rabbis.

A lot of social outreach to non-Jewish community, which that's another bugbear of mine, to be honest: **the insularity of the Jewish community** in Melbourne and the - let's say you've got ten bucks you want to give away, charities 1 through 10, it seems, are all Jewish charities before you consider anywhere else when there's, I think, plenty if not more needy people in our community. The way that it seems that people sort of really look really inward. It bothers me and they don't do that there - of course they get behind Jewish things, but they sort of have a close relationship with the major homeless shelter. Like, the wife's husband is like the rabbi of - which is actually a famous Anglican church there that does a heap of outreach and social justice stuff. They go to Alabama on a social justice thing around Pesach time and they just intertwine it with the broader community, and I just thought that was really cool. And that insularity bothers me a lot in Melbourne, the way our community sometimes seems to have forgotten our victimisation and the issues that were important to us 60 years ago and we seem to side with - oppressors is a strong word, but side with the powerful at the expense of the marginalised. That bothers me a lot in our community as well and this sort of - the values of this place was really aligned with mine.

Interviewer: I hear you. If I may, taking it back a few steps, it sounds like there was a strong Mum in the picture?

Ethan: Yeah, very strong, and that was parenting style and all sorts of other issues, but there was **resentment** towards the way - so, for example, Friday night - we're not particularly religious. We've always driven and done stuff on the sabbath. We've always gone to the football, played football on the sabbath, driven, blah, blah, blah, but mum would never let us break shabbat dinner commitments even for really quite exceptional things, almost there was no reason to break that commitment. That's partly family commitment but also - so, that just **bred some resentment at times**, I must say.

Interviewer: I hear you. Thank you. If we're going in age, Adrian? Can you think of an anecdote, an experience, something about upbringing that explains where you see yourself Jewishly now?

Adrian: Yeah, sure. Okay. I think I don't have an anecdote as such, but more kind of the shaping is - I have to kind of agree with Ethan that Mum was the driving force here and with many things, **Mum** was the driving force. She's a very passionate lady, and particularly so in regards to things she feels are important, like religion and education. And I think similarly to Ethan, I'm a bit **torn** here because on the one hand, a lot of the good things that happened in my life are as a result of my mum forcing me to do things, but conversely a number of the things that I don't look back fondly upon are also because of the things she forced me to do. And, so, that's tough for her. She did what she felt was always right. It never came from a bad place. But I think maybe I - I mean, who knows? It's kind of the hindsight thing, crystal ball thing. Would I be a different person if we weren't kind of essentially forced to do certain things? [Pauses] And that could be a better or a worse person, by the way. So, with regards to Judaism, I don't - yeah, I don't feel - I feel connected to Judaism, connected to the

Commented [User12]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (systemic), Relational (family), and Individual levels.

Macro-Level (Communal/Systemic): The siblings discuss the "insularity of the Jewish community in Melbourne" and the "private school atmosphere". Helen explicitly distinguishes between "Jewish" values and the values of an "affluent community".

Cross-reference: Point continues below (!!)

Commented [User13]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme distinguishes between **identity optimization** (refining stable commitments) and fundamental crises, mapping the move from **conferred** (parental) to **agentic** (chosen) identity.

The Transition to Agentic Identity: Ethan notes that moving to a city in the USA was the first time in his life that his Judaism was a "total decision" and "up to us," moving away from the **conferred identity** of being "forced to do stuff" in Melbourne.

Cross-reference: Continued from above (^^)

community, but would I have felt that way in any place that I lived? Probably, I would think so. So, I'm not sure if I'm answering the question here.

Interviewer: Are there any experiences that were forms of connection, that either sort of inspired or repelled certain forms of connection?

Adrian: Yeah, I guess the connection for us - well, for me - the ongoing connection throughout my life was that connection to the football club, and that was never overtly Jewish, but it was always representing the Jewish community and that was always really known with everybody you played against. Ajax was that Jewish club. So, in a way that kind of - it's not religious in any respect, but it shaped - it always maintained that connection. Similarly, through school: we all went to [elite private boarding school] for a year and I always felt - I mean, growing up - I was at a Jewish school for 15 years and then leaving for a year, I always felt that connection to come back and be a part of that and be close to my friends. I don't know if that flows on to being close to the community as such, but yeah, being close to friends.

And now - I mean, it's not [US city], but a few years ago [Adrian's wife] and I moved to Port Melbourne and really enjoyed the anonymity. [Laughs] Not knowing people when you go anytime to a cafe or the shops or whatever has been really really nice. But that I don't think is a reflection of how I feel Jewishly. And we'd probably stay out there if it wasn't for what Ethan experienced this morning in terms of that commute to a Jewish day school from outside the bagel belt.

Interviewer: The bagel belt. Helen? In terms of upbringing, in terms of home experiences, school experiences or others, can you think of an anecdote or an example that sort of makes sense of or might have inspired how you've chosen to do Jewish now?

Helen: I think that growing up in Caulfield, going to [Traditional Jewish school], playing basketball for Maccabi, going to Maccabee, going to JCC games in America, our whole world - until [elite private boarding school] - my whole world was Jewish. Like, literally I didn't have one friend that wasn't Jewish.

I remember we were in Africa and I met this girl there and she wasn't Jewish and she was talking about Christmas, and I remember - I don't know how old we were when we were in Africa, maybe 12? And I remember saying to her, ashamed almost, we don't "celebrate Christmas". And that's something that I think has continued throughout life, is that **I've got this kind of conflict where I'm so proud to be Jewish, but at the same time - oh, I'm going to cry** [bursts into tears]- I'm almost ashamed to be Jewish and I don't know where that comes from. But what I do love about the Jewish community, and it's the exact opposite to what Ethan dislikes about the Jewish community is that I love feeling part of a community. I love that in good times and bad times, the Jewish community - like, I feel like we're one. We're there for one another. And I think that's what I also love about Israel, that take politics aside, when you think about Israel, and this is after the Holocaust exile existed, was that there's always a place for us, and maybe that comes back to why I don't always feel like - oh, God [sobs]! This is probably a bit much for the office. One sec. I'm good. I'm good. That on one side I'm so proud to be Jewish, but on the other

Commented [User14]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (systemic), Relational (family), and Individual levels.

Relational-Level (Family Dynamics): The transcript is dominated by the influence of a "very strong" and "passionate" mother. Adrian notes the **relational filtering** of this influence: it was a source of "good things" but also created memories he does not "look back fondly upon".

Cross-reference: Point continues from above (++)

Commented [User15]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity rather than researcher-dictated scales.

"Bagel Belt": Adrian's term for the geographically concentrated Jewish area of Melbourne, used to discuss the trade-off between communal proximity and anonymity.

side I almost am a bit ashamed to be Jewish, and I don't know where that stems from, I don't know where that comes from.

Maybe it comes from partially from Ethan's joke with the Range Rover, the Jewish white privilege. There's white privilege that is spoken about a lot lately, but there's definitely a **Jewish white privilege** that comes from the community that, again, Ethan - Ethan and I had this discussion about if you had 10 dollars - I said, "if I had 10 dollars and I had a friend who was struggling, I would give it to that friend". Where, Ethan said, "if I had 10 dollars, I would look wider to the wider community of who needs this". And I think that's just something that has always been - that for me has made me feel whole, which conflicts with my not feeling whole. My life is a bunch of contradictions.

For me, growing up, I look - and this has only come as a mum, because I remember when I was a kid and Mum would say "hey, it's time to do the Sukkah, decorate the Sukkah", and that often fell to me. I don't know why, boys. Why did that fall to me?

But I remember I hated it. Every year it was like, oh, my god, it's that time of year again. And now I look back on those times and think how lucky was I that we had that time to all come together.

And while at times it seems like a burden that we come together so often, I also love that - it's like you don't even have to think about coming together because we're together every week. The extended family is together every week. And I think that that has formed a huge part of my identity.

I think of highlights of my life. JCC games, Maccabee games, coming together from all over the world to play basketball and be - I don't know; you just meet people from overseas that have similar life experiences, and while the flipside of that is often really rewarding as well, that kind of just makes - I don't know. I think of Judaism, it feels me with tingles and excitement, and that's probably because I don't look into the political side as much. It's more about the community and the traditions and what we did and what we do now. Yeah.

Interviewer: I've never met a person who is consistent in everything, Helen. I don't think that's weird. I'm no psychologist, but serenity to me seems to be associated with people who haven't thought about things too deeply. It's when you start picking when you realise those really interesting complexities and contradictions.

Ethan: For what it's worth, we're at sort of a strange point in our lives. A lot of confusion because things haven't gone sort of the way we expected and we sort of didn't get closure where we were living.

But, yeah, just on what Helen was saying, I guess it's something that has really bothered me. I don't necessarily think that it's got anything necessarily to do with Judaism, but certainly being part of the community, I do see the value and I've always valued it and at times enjoyed it a lot, and definitely consider myself part of it now, but I do - for me, it's always felt we, while objectively doing things that by anyone's metric around the world would be a great life and they are, I've always been very deeply troubled by what feels like a fate, or sort of **conveyor belt** of life that you're, we're on. And this is entirely my own feelings

Commented [User16]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity rather than researcher-dictated scales.

"Jewish White Privilege": Helen's term to describe the affluent, insular nature of the community, which she admits creates a sense of "conflict" and "shame."

Commented [User17]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (systemic), Relational (family), and Individual levels.

Individual-Level (The Self-Concept): Helen articulates a "shame/pride" dichotomy, while Ethan connects his **individual-level** "personality thing" (resenting being forced) to his **macro-level** separation from the Orthodox community.

Cross-reference: Point continues (==)

Commented [User18]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme captures "interactional action units" where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to corroborate or challenge shared history, preventing the distortion of personal or family narratives.

Domestic History and Gender Roles: Helen challenges her brothers to verify a specific childhood memory: "I remember when I was a kid and Mum would say 'hey, it's time to do the Sukkah'... that often fell to me. I don't know why, boys. Why did that fall to me?"

of course. Most people seem to be very happy with, for example, sending their kids to the same school they went to in the same neighbourhood and still living in that neighbourhood where they lived with their parents and etcetera. And those things have lots of positive effects on our lives, and I can see those too, but that's something that has always deeply troubled me and probably means that I probably sort of won't embed myself in the Jewish community as much as maybe I thought I would have 20 years ago. And I don't even know if that's a Judaism thing or that's just me and my issues, or whatever. But yeah, I think that one thing that really troubles me about my mum's worldview in particular is just how - and it probably goes hand-in-hand with the dedication to the community and the religion and things, but it does feel that it does **narrow someone's perspective**, maybe their perspective on the world. And as you can hear from where we've been on our holidays and things as a family, it's always something our parents tried to do for us, is open our eyes up a bit, which I really appreciate. But that our community can be sometimes entirely inward-looking, which is great for sort of protecting our own wellbeing or institutions or whatever, but I think there are big costs to that. And that's sort of what plays into where we will send our kids to school and things and where we will live, actually.

Interviewer: Yes. Wow, thank you all for sharing. If there's any last thoughts, that would be amazing.

Adrian: I think my final thought would be there's - I think we touched on before - is that balancing between the push and the pull, and not - and your example [interviewer] of not making things compulsory and attracting nice crowds, but then making things compulsory and then attracting but potentially losing on people coming if you don't make it compulsory. I think it's a really tough balance to strike, but I think it's, from an initial perspective at least, giving people the opportunity to come off their own bat might create a more positive experience or more positive feelings towards Judaism, initially perhaps. Yeah, so that's my two cents and my bugs.

Helen: Me, a lot of what I don't like about the Jewish community is not necessarily to do with the Jewish community; it's more to do with the **private school atmosphere**. I think that a lot of the values – and I'm struggling with this in life – a lot of the values that we live with and that our kids are exposed to are due to being a part of a more affluent community, and I think that it hasn't got anything to do with being Jewish, and that that for me is something that I have to kind of grapple with and work out. Yeah, I think that I often put the negative onto the Jewish, but it's not the Jewish. It's rather the values that are being instilled by being a part of a private school and that's something I need to work out for myself.

Interviewer: It just sounds like so much balancing. There's the balancing between choice and imposition; there's the balancing between Jewish and secular; privileged and sensitivity to others that might be struggling.

Amazing. Thank you. Thank you very much for sharing. I know you're busy, so please get back to your wonderful lives and your beautiful children. Thank you.

Adrian: Good luck. Thank you.

Interviewer: Thank you so much.

Commented [User19]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and idiosyncratic labels used by participants to describe the "substance" of their identity rather than researcher-dictated scales.

"The Conveyor Belt of Life": Ethan's metaphor for the rigid systemic expectations of the Melbourne community—living in the same neighbourhood and sending kids to the same school—which he feels can "**narrow** someone's perspective."

Commented [User20]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (systemic), Relational (family), and Individual levels.

Mesosystemic Filtering: The siblings negotiate the "balancing" of where to send their children to school—weighing [Traditional Jewish school] vs. [Progressive school] vs. [Bundist school] against logistics and the "informal Jewish curriculum"

Cross-reference: Point continued (&&)

Commented [User21]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme operationalises the **mesosystemic laboratory** by mapping identity across Macro (systemic), Relational (family), and Individual levels.

Macro-Level (Communal/Systemic): The siblings discuss the "insularity of the Jewish community in Melbourne" and the "private school atmosphere". Helen explicitly distinguishes between "Jewish" values and the values of an "affluent community".

Cross-reference: Point continues here and above (!!)

Ethan: Thanks for including us. Good luck.

Interviewer: Thank you. Thank you. Bye.

Ethan: Chat to you later. Bye.

END OF TRANSCRIPT